

months now"

Q. Would you also be pushing to curb the authority of the President, including the power to dismiss elected governments?

A. It falls under the purview of the charter of democracy and we are going to follow what is in the charter.

Q. How would you describe your relations with Zardari now?

A. He hasn't spoken to me for two months now. I have no personal animosity with Zardari. My differences are only based on certain principles and I wanted Zardari to abide by the promises that we had made to each other.

Q. So rejoining the Government is not on your agenda?

A. We haven't thought about it. So much water has flown under the bridge since we were last part of it. Therefore, unless there are some strong confidence-building measures, we may not like to think about it.

Q. Pakistan is on the brink of collapse with rising violence, an economic meltdown and Talibanisation. What needs to be done?

A. No party can single-handedly tackle the magnitude of the crisis that Pakistan faces. Much of it is a legacy of Musharraf's martial regime. Instead of tackling these issues, political parties have so far been fighting each other. We hope that better sense prevails now.

Q. Zardari's Government has not inspired much confidence in India after the Mumbai attacks. What needs to be done now to improve relations between India and Pakistan?

A. India and Pakistan should reach out to each other and repose confidence. We are making very slow progress and we need to be transparent with each other and move with speed so that each side feels we are serious. A joint investigation of the whole episode must take place and that would inspire confidence in each other.

perhaps even more astutely, he realised that with the myriad economic, legal and security problems facing any new government, it was in his interest to bide his time.

Zardari realised early enough that his main rival would be Sharif and after the election steadily worked at undermining the former prime minister's popularity even winning the first few rounds. In disgust, Sharif pulled his PML(N) out of the federal Government in September 2008 over Zardari reneging on his promise to restore all the judges after they combined forces to have Musharraf step down as president. In the past six months, Zardari thought Sharif was on the mat and plotted to tie him up in more knots. But his fatal miscalculation occurred even as the lawyers threatened to bring their movement to Islamabad to stage an indefinite sit-in in front of the Parliament. First came the Supreme Court judgement in late February upholding the disqualification of Sharif and his brother Shahbaz Sharif, which immediately removed the latter as Punjab's chief minister.

In the charged scenario wherein most people believed that the deposed Chief Justice Iftikhar Chaudhry had not been restored because the controversial sitting Chief Justice A.H. Dogar enjoyed Zardari's patronage, the Sharifs accused Zardari of being behind the judgement. What convinced most that the judgement was "engineered by the presidency" was the fact that Zardari then immediately imposed governor's rule in the province instead of having its Assembly elect a new leader from Sharif's party. Tensions had been brewing between the PML(N) and PPP Governor Salman Taseer and this act was seen as a blatant attempt to give Taseer time to cobble together the PPP's own majority.

For his part, Zardari may have wanted to stave off the possibility of the PML(N)-led Punjab government using its resources to aid the lawyers' Long March. But the effect of his actions was to push the Sharifs—who had initially seemed to waver about the plans for a sit-in at Islamabad—firmly into the lawyers' camp. With nothing left to lose,

the Sharifs became the most potent political force in the movement and focused their ire on Zardari himself. As the Sharifs corralled public discontent, and the momentum of the Long March grew, it became obvious that Zardari had shot himself in the foot.

In the end, even as the Government panicked, making large-scale arrests and attempting to seal off Punjab, the image of political chaos in Pakistan sent jitters through Western capitals and the country's all-important military. For both, this was needless distraction from the pressing issue of tackling mounting security threats and a precarious economic situation. American Special Envoy Richard Holbrooke and Secretary of State Hillary Clinton as well as UK Foreign Minister David Miliband made urgent phone calls to Zardari and Sharif. Army Chief Ashfaq Parvez Kayani too stepped up his meetings with Zardari and Prime Minister Yousaf Raza Gilani. Although the Americans denied putting any pressure on Pakistan's leaders, it was obvious that the threat of disruption to much-needed aid in the pipeline was presented to Zardari.

The high profile resignation of PPP's Senate leader and minister Raza Rabbani, followed by Information Minister Sherry Rehman who quit over curbs on the media instituted at the behest of the presidency, began to indicate cracks within the PPP itself. Sources claim that on the day a stubborn Zardari finally saw the writing on the wall and backed down, Kayani informed him the army would not be prepared to "defend" Islamabad in the face of massive crowds.

It was the first time in Pakistan's recent history that street power and public pressure—much of it channelled through the media—had forced a government to back down. The PPP is now attempting to put a spin on its humiliation by claiming Zardari had never been opposed to the restoration of Chaudhry and his fellow judges, but this explanation has few takers. The widespread celebrations are as much